

WORKED EXAMPLE

Project Closure Report — a complete worked example

One report, end to end, for a project that broadly succeeded and missed several things. The grey notes beside each section are commentary for you, not part of the document. Read the report first and ignore them; then read them and see what each section is doing.

STATUS

Illustrative — not a real DEWR project

LENGTH

14 sections, about 2,500 words

ALIGNED TO

The DTA closure reporting standard — all seven criteria

DEWR DIGITAL EXPERIENCE AND SOLUTIONS

Provider Application Status

Project Closure Report

1. Document purpose

This report closes the Provider Application Status project and transfers six benefits, four residual risks, two follow-on actions and one unresolved dependency to the owners named in sections 9 and 10.

It supports two decisions: the Senior Responsible Officer's decision to stand down project governance, and the Chief Financial Officer's treatment of \$47.3m of capitalised and expensed cost. Section 14 records the acceptance of those transfers.

WHY IT READS THIS WAY

Names the decisions and who takes them. A purpose section that says 'this document reports on the closure of the project' has restated the title and told nobody whether the document is theirs to act on.

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2. Project overview

Employment service providers could not reliably see how far a participant's application had progressed. Information sat across three systems, none of it provider-facing, so providers rang the support line to ask — generating roughly 34,000 avoidable contacts a year against a support function sized for 20,000.

The project delivered a self-service application status view in the provider portal, drawing on the case management system and the payments platform, with status definitions agreed with Policy Branch.

Known internally as Provider Status; appears as PANDA in planning papers before August 2023. New Policy Proposal reference 2023-DEWR-114. Delivered August 2023 to June 2026 by an internal team of 14 with an integration vendor, at a final cost of \$47.3m against \$38.1m originally approved.

WHY IT READS THIS WAY

Written for someone who has never heard of it. The internal name, the old codename and the NPP reference are how a reader in three years finds this at all; the contact numbers are how they judge whether it is worth reading.

3. Objectives

Objective as approved: 'Provide employment service providers with self-service visibility of participant application status, reducing avoidable contact with the provider support line.'

Assessment: achieved. The status view was released to all providers in March 2026 and is in routine use, with 78 per cent of active provider organisations accessing it at least weekly.

One objective was withdrawn. 'Extend status visibility to participants directly' was removed from scope in November 2025 by the Project Board, on advice that participant-facing release required a privacy assessment that could not be completed in the funded period. It is not delivered and is not counted as a benefit.

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Quotes the objective as originally written, not as it came to be described, and records the withdrawn objective with the date and who decided.

Scope that quietly disappears is the most common thing a closure report is asked about later.

4. Business outcomes and key results

The outcome that justified the investment was a reduction in avoidable contact, and it has moved less than forecast.

OUTCOMES AGAINST TARGET

Outcome	Measure	Target	Actual	Basis
Reduced avoidable contact	Contacts per application	0.60	0.83	Measured
Reduced avoidable contact	Annual contact volume	20,400	28,900	Measured
Faster provider decisions	Median days to provider action	4.0	4.2	Measured
Provider confidence	Provider satisfaction (portal)	—	+11 pts	Measured, no target set

WHY IT READS THIS WAY

Objective, outcome and key result kept apart. The objective was met and the outcome largely was not — providers use the screen and still ring. That is the finding, and it disappears the moment the three are merged into one sentence about success.

5. What we did not achieve

Contact reduction. The business case forecast a fall to 0.60 contacts per application by June 2026. Measured at 0.83. The shortfall is approximately 8,500 contacts a year, worth about \$1.9m annually against the forecast saving of \$3.1m.

The cause is forecast error rather than delivery failure. The system performs to specification and take-up is high. The forecast assumed

[Skip to learning content](#) to visibility, based on the 2023 online judgement rollout — which was a mandatory channel change. This is an

opt-in information screen, and the comparator was wrong. Recorded as lesson LP-2026-118.

Cost. Final cost \$47.3m against \$38.1m originally approved, an overrun of \$9.2m or 24 per cent. Both rebaselines were approved (section 7). The original approval was still exceeded.

Participant-facing extension. Withdrawn November 2025, as recorded at section 3.

WHY IT READS THIS WAY

Its own heading, early, in the same units as the original commitment, and no compensating success anywhere in it. Distinguishing forecast error from delivery failure is what makes it useful rather than merely honest — one is a lesson for the next business case, the other would be a lesson for the next delivery team.

6. Milestones

The integration slip drove the schedule. A change to the whole-of-department identity broker token lifetime in September 2025 broke session handling in user acceptance testing; the rework is described at sections 5 and 7.

PLANNED AGAINST ACTUAL				
Milestone	Original plan	Rebaselined	Actual	Variance to original
Discovery complete	Feb 2024	—	Feb 2024	On time
Alpha assessment	Aug 2024	Oct 2024	Oct 2024	+8 weeks
Private beta	Mar 2025	Jul 2025	Aug 2025	+22 weeks
Integration complete	Jun 2025	Jan 2026	Feb 2026	+35 weeks
Public release	Sep 2025	Mar 2026	Mar 2026	+26 weeks

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WHY IT READS THIS WAY

Both columns shown. A milestone table where every actual equals the rebaselined date — which this one nearly is — tells a reader nothing until the original is beside it.

7. Financial summary

Training, change management and post-release defect work were reassessed at closure and moved from capital to expense, reducing the capitalised figure by \$3.5m from the position carried during delivery. Discovery costs relating to the three options not pursued were expensed.

Original approved (Aug 2023)	\$38.1m	
Revision 1 (Mar 2025)	\$43.5m	reconciliation module added to
Revision 2 (Nov 2025)	\$47.3m	integration rework, identity br
Final actual	\$47.3m	
Variance to original approval	+\$9.2m	(+24%)
Capitalised	\$28.4m	
Expensed	\$18.9m	
of which discovery and options	\$3.2m	
of which training and change	\$2.1m	
of which post-release defect work	\$1.4m	
Recurring cost from FY2027-28	\$310k p.a.	licences, hosting, support
Transferred to	Cost centre PLT-4420,	Platform Services
Accepted by	Budget holder,	14 July 2026

WHY IT READS THIS WAY

The chain, not the endpoint. Note the recurring cost has a cost centre and a named acceptance date — a run cost handed to 'operations' with no budget line is how a licence lapses eighteen months later.

8. Completion criteria and quality

Seven completion criteria were agreed at investment decision. Six are met. One — bulk status export for provider back-office systems — was waived by the Senior Responsible Officer on 3 June 2026 and moved to the platform backlog.

Quality: 14 known defects were accepted into production, two at severity 3 and twelve at severity 4, all owned in the platform backlog with the Assistant Director, Platform Services. Peak load tested to three times

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en security findings above low.

WHY IT READS THIS WAY

Quality is not scope. 'Passed user acceptance testing' would report that a meeting happened; defect counts by severity, load headroom, accessibility conformance and security position report whether the thing works.

9. Benefits and their owners

Measured against benefits management plan version 3 (November 2025). One formal change was made to the plan during delivery: the participant-facing benefit was removed in November 2025 when that scope was withdrawn, and no replacement benefit was substituted.

Five of six benefits have a named owner who has seen the figure and accepted it, with the acceptance date shown. The sixth is unresolved and is recorded at section 10.

Two benefits are non-cashable. No budget line falls as a result of either, and neither is claimed as a saving. Ongoing measurement and its governance transfer to the benefit owners named above, reporting to the Service Performance Committee half-yearly until June 2028; the project's own benefits governance ceases at closure.

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BENEFITS AGAINST THE BENEFITS MANAGEMENT PLAN (BMP V3, NOV 2025)

Benefit	Planned value	% realised at closure	Full realisation expected	Owner (accepted)
Reduced avoidable contact	\$3.1m p.a.	39%	Not expected to reach plan — see s.5	Director, Provider Support (14 Jul 2026)
Reduced manual reconciliation	\$6.2m p.a.	0% — starts FY2027-28	Jun 2028	Director, Payments Operations (22 Jul 2026)
Faster provider action	Non-cashable	Partly — 4.2 days against 4.0	Dec 2026	Director, Provider Support (14 Jul 2026)
Reduced rework from status errors	\$0.4m p.a.	62%	Jun 2027	Director, Case Management (14 Jul 2026)
Provider satisfaction	Non-cashable	Achieved, +11 pts	Realised	Director, Provider Support (14 Jul 2026)
Support staffing avoidance	Cost avoidance \$0.9m	0%	Unknown	NOT ACCEPTED — see s.10 R4

WHY IT READS THIS WAY

Criterion 3 measures the report against the benefits management plan, not the business case narrative — so name the plan and its version, give the percentage realised and the expected date for each, and say what happens to benefit governance after closure. Marking the two non-cashable benefits explicitly is what stops the report claiming \$8.7m of savings it cannot deliver.

10. Outstanding risks, issues, dependencies and actions

RISK R1 Identity broker token lifetime may change again without notice.
 Platform Services · Medium · Registered as a consuming platform Identity; notification requested.
 Platform Services register PS-R-118 · Review Dec 2026

RISK R4 Support staffing avoidance benefit (\$0.9m) has no agreed owner.

UNTRANSFERRED. Provider Support has been approached twice and has not accepted it, on the grounds that staffing levels are set centrally. Referred to the SR0 for allocation before signature.

ISSUE I7 Notification wording continues to generate calls that the status screen was expected to prevent.
Owner: Director, Eligibility Policy → follow-on action A3.

DEP D1 Bulk export (waived criterion, s.8) depends on the provider gateway roadmap. Owed by: Provider Systems (external vendor). Chased by: AD Platform Services. No committed date.

ACT A3 Revise notification wording. Owner: Director, Eligibility Policy. Due 30 Nov 2026. If not done: contact reduction stays near 0.83 and the benefit owner cannot act, the driver being outside their control.

ACT A7 Move the duplicate-exclusion script from the analyst's personal repository into the branch analytics repository, with the measurement note. Owner: AD Performance Reporting. Due 30 Sep 2026. If not done: the baseline figures cannot be reproduced.

WHY IT READS THIS WAY

A transfer table, not a filtered status log. Every row has a person, a destination and a date — and R4 says UNTRANSFERRED in plain sight rather than being assigned to a branch that never agreed. That single line is what makes the signature at section 14 mean something.

11. Assurance activities

All assurance activities in the Assurance Plan agreed with the Digital Transformation Agency were completed. One was substituted: the planned Gate 5 operational review was replaced by an internal readiness assessment in February 2026, on the Project Board's decision, because public release had moved to March and a Gate 5 before release would have assessed nothing.

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ASSURANCE COMPLETED

Activity	Date	Key finding	What we did
Gate 2 — procurement strategy	Nov 2023	Integration scope understated	Accepted; scope and estimate revised before market approach
Gate 4 — readiness for service	Mar 2025	Release too large to absorb change	Adopted; split into two releases
Internal readiness assessment	Feb 2026	Support model undersized	Partly adopted; two roles added, third deferred
Gate 6 — benefits realisation	Jun 2026	Benefit B6 had no owner	Not resolved; carried as R4 at section 10

Was it worth it? The Gate 4 recommendation to split the release is the clearest value: the second release absorbed the identity broker change without a further slip, against a plausible counterfactual of a further six to eight weeks. Gate 2's finding on integration scope was correct and acted on, though the revised estimate still proved 3.4 times short.

Gate 6 identified the unowned benefit that remains unresolved at closure. The finding was right and the project could not act on it, because allocation sits above the Project Board. That is recorded here rather than presented as an assurance failure.

WHY IT READS THIS WAY

Criterion 5 of the closure reporting standard, and the one most often answered with a list of dates. Findings and what was done about them make it Emerging. The closing paragraphs — whether the assurance was worth its cost, including a recommendation that was correct and still not acted on — are what make it Strong.

12. Lessons and recommendations

LP-2026-118 — Forecasting take-up for opt-in services. Context: any business case forecasting behaviour change from an opt-in digital channel. Event: contact reduction forecast at 40 per cent using the 2023 comparator; that was a mandatory channel. Finding: contact reduction 18 per cent. Cost: \$1.9m of forecast annual benefit not realised. Action: forecast opt-in take-up from

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opt-in precedents only, and state the comparator in the business case so it can be challenged.

LP-2026-204 — Consuming shared identity services. Context: any build depending on the whole-of-department identity broker. Event: token lifetime changed September 2025 with no notification to consuming programs; session handling broke in user acceptance testing. Cost: integration rework at 3.4 times the original estimate, \$3.8m, 11 weeks. Action: register as a consuming system with Platform Identity at design and request change notification — there is no automatic list, you must ask.

Recommendation R1 — that business cases forecasting behaviour change state the comparator initiative they draw on, so the assumption is visible at approval rather than at closure. Directed to: Assistant Secretary, Investment Assurance. Status: accepted, to apply from the 2027-28 NPP round.

WHY IT READS THIS WAY

Lessons carry context, event, cost and action, and go to a pool a stranger would search. The recommendation is a different kind of thing — it is aimed at this entity's process, and filing it as a lesson would have sent it somewhere nobody with authority to act would read it.

13. Handover, artefacts and records

Operational support transferred to Platform Services on 12 June 2026. Before transfer, the receiving team completed two routine changes and one diagnostic task with the delivery team unavailable; the eleven questions raised became the handover backlog and were closed by 30 June.

Known fragility disclosed at handover: the nightly reconciliation fails if the provider feed arrives after 02:00 (twice observed, recovered by manual rerun, no alerting); the eligibility rules engine is compiled rather than configured, so an urgent policy change cannot be applied in under five working days.

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ARTEFACTS

Artefact	Location	Owner	Retention
Original business case (Aug 2023)	ATTACHED to this report	SRO	Per schedule
Lessons learned register (full)	ATTACHED to this report	AD Delivery Assurance	Per schedule
Benefits management plan v3	Governance library	Director, Provider Support	Business
Architecture decision records	Platform wiki / ADR	AD Platform Services	Business
Data dictionary and export schema	Records store REC-2026-0881	AD Information Governance	7 years
Baseline measurement extracts	Records store REC-2026-0881	AD Performance Reporting	7 years
Benefits realisation plan	Governance library	Director, Provider Support	Business
Contracts and final acceptance	Procurement records	Director, Procurement	Per schedule
Test evidence and accessibility audit	Platform wiki	AD Platform Services	Business

Attached to this report, as required by the closure reporting standard: the original business case as agreed by Government (August 2023), and the full lessons learned register. Both are attachments rather than references, so a reader can check the report against its own source without requesting anything.

WHY IT READS THIS WAY

Two of these are attachments the standard requires rather than merely lists: the original business case (criterion 1) and the lessons learned register (criterion 7). The handover was tested rather than signed, and the fragility is written down — the two things delivery teams most often skip to save time, and the other feels like confessing. Every artefact has an owner; a list of names is not an index.

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14. Agreement on closure

Signed by the Senior Responsible Officer, confirming that the benefits, risks, dependencies and actions recorded at sections 9 and 10 have been accepted by the owners named there.

Exception: risk R4 (support staffing avoidance benefit, \$0.9m) remains untransferred and is referred to the Deputy Secretary for allocation.

Signature is given on the basis that this exception is recorded and pursued, not resolved.

WHY IT READS THIS WAY

The signature is tied to the transfers, so signing is an act with content. And the exception is above the signature, not buried — the SRO signs knowing exactly what has not been accepted, which is the entire reason the section exists.

This project delivered its objective, missed its outcome, ran 24 per cent over its original approval, and left one benefit without an owner. It is a normal project. A closure report that made it sound like an unqualified success would have been easy to write, would have been signed without comment, and would have taught the next team nothing.